

CONCEPT PLAN NO. 001
FIRST EDITION · SPRING



The Saltwater Cottage

A 60-page concept plan for the model house of the home you've always loved before you've ever lived in it.

COLOPHON

The Saltwater Cottage

A concept plan for a small-scale architectural model, designed and drawn by Ashleigh. Not a construction document — a love letter to a home.

PLAN	No. 001 · The Saltwater Cottage
EDITION	First Edition
SCALE	1:48 ($\frac{1}{4}" = 1'-0"$)
FOOTPRINT	11.5" × 8.5" finished model
PAGES	60
FORMAT	Print-ready PDF · A4 portrait
DESIGNER	Ashleigh, M.Arch candidate
STUDIO	Just Me Ashleigh · Dream House Atelier

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A LETTER

Hi — it's me. Ashleigh.

I'm in my final year of architecture school, which means I've spent the last four years thinking about buildings I cannot yet afford to build. So I started drawing them anyway.

This is the first plan in a small collection I'm calling the Dream House Atelier. Each one is a complete concept for a model house — an HGTV Dream Home, in miniature, that you build with your own two hands at your own kitchen table. None of them are construction-ready. None of them are full of structural callouts and code references. They're all just houses I would love to live in, drawn carefully enough that you can love them too.

The Saltwater Cottage is where I'd want to spend a long August. I built her around a wraparound porch, a vaulted great room that opens to the ocean, and a bunk room with a porthole window where four kids can stack into bed at the end of a sandy day. There's a widow's walk, because every coastal cottage deserves one. There's a Dutch door, because what is more inviting than a Dutch door.

The model is meant to be made from foam board and balsa wood — supplies you can pick up at any craft store. I've designed it for an intermediate hobbyist, which means I assume you've held a craft knife before but not that you've ever built a house. I'll walk with you through every step.

Take your time. Make it yours. Send me a photo when you're done.

— Ash

Ashleigh · the dream house atelier · spring

just me, ashleigh

ABOUT THE STUDIO

Just Me Ashleigh

A small atelier of dream house concept plans. Drawn, written, and stitched together by one person at a kitchen table.

THE IDEA

Architecture school teaches you to draw buildings other people will pay to build. The Atelier flips that around: it sells the dream. Each plan is a complete concept for a small architectural model that anyone can build by hand — a tactile way to spend an afternoon (or a winter) inside a house that doesn't exist yet, may never exist, but feels like home.

WHAT YOU'RE BUYING

A 60-page printable PDF. A complete materials list, every cut sheet, every step. Drawings done by hand. A point of view about how the house wants to be lived in. No flat-pack kit, no shipping, no waiting — just the plans, the inspiration, and the trust that you can do it.

WHO IT'S FOR

Anyone who's ever lingered on a real estate listing they couldn't quite afford. Anyone redecorating in their head. Anyone who needs a long winter project. Architecture students. Designers. Crafters. Grandparents and grandkids. People who love houses.



*"Houses, in miniature, for
the rest of us."*

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just me, ashleigh

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just me, ashleigh

ORIENTATION

How to use this plan

Read it cover to cover before you cut a single thing. The book is your project plan as much as your instruction manual.

THE FLOW

Chapters I–III are the dream — the design intent, the rooms, the way the house wants to feel. Read these like a magazine. Chapter IV walks you through your shopping list. Chapter V is your cut sheets. Chapter VI is your build, broken into eight phases of one to three afternoons each. Chapter VII is for after.

HOW TO PRINT THE TEMPLATES

Templates live on pages 43–46. Print them at **100% scale, no fit-to-page**. Every template page includes a 6" calibration ruler at the top — check it with a real ruler before you cut.

WHAT SCALE IS THIS?

Everything is drawn at **1:48** — meaning ¼" on the model equals 1 foot in the real house. The finished cottage measures about 11.5" wide by 8.5" deep by 7.25" tall to the widow's walk railing. It will fit on a generous bookshelf.

HOW LONG WILL THIS TAKE?

Plan for **about 30–40 hours** of build time, spread across two to six weeks. Most of that is patience — letting glue dry, letting paint cure, letting yourself enjoy the slow build of something nice.

SKILL LEVEL

This plan assumes you've used a craft knife before. If you haven't, that's fine — please buy a self-healing mat and a fresh package of #11 blades, watch one ten-minute video on technique, and you'll be ready.

*"If you find yourself frustrated, stop. Make tea.
Come back when the glue has dried."*

— ash

MAKE IT YOURS

Change the colors. Swap the shingles for clapboard. Add a third dormer. Build her in pink. The plan is a starting point — your house is meant to look like you.

CHAPTER I

— one —

The Dream

Where we live in this house before we build it. The mood. The light. The smell of salt on cedar shingles. The dream is the deliverable — everything that follows is just service to it.

just me, ashleigh

DESIGN STATEMENT

The cottage, in one breath.

A modest, four-bedroom shingled cottage of about 2,200 square feet, sited end-on to a 0.4-acre coastal lot. The footprint is simple. The roof is dramatic. The ocean is everywhere — visible from the great room, the primary suite, and the daybed on the screened porch where you'll fall asleep on rainy afternoons.

MASSING

A simple gabled rectangle with two attached wings — a mudroom on the west and a screened porch on the east. A single dramatic gable rises in the center, capped by a widow's walk and a chimney just off-axis.

INDOOR / OUTDOOR

A 60-foot wraparound porch on the south. A 240-square-foot screened porch on the east. A back deck and unfinished pergola on the north, where the ocean is. The house is built around its thresholds.

LIGHT & VIEW

Three oversized 9-over-9 windows on the north elevation pull the ocean into the great room. The primary suite has a window seat. Every bedroom gets morning sun.

Quiet exterior. Loud interior. The shingles will weather silver and the trim will stay white — but inside, the great room ceiling is sea-fog blue, the kitchen uppers are sea glass, the headboard is deep marine, and the front door, when you arrive, is the same blue as the deepest part of the sound.

WHAT THIS COTTAGE REJECTS

- Open-plan-for-its-own-sake.
- Greige.
- Recessed cans as the only light source.
- Anything that came in a flat box.
- Sliding barn doors. (Sorry.)

WHAT THIS COTTAGE CELEBRATES

- Wraparound porches, painted floors, ceiling fans.
- Salt-air-weathered cedar going grey on its own time.
- One color of blue used five different ways.
- Sea grass at the threshold. Sand in the mudroom.
- A Dutch door. Always a Dutch door. *just me, ashleigh*

INSPIRATION

Where she comes from

The Saltwater Cottage is a love letter to the shingled vernacular of the American Northeast — but a small, careful one, with the volume turned down.

NANTUCKET

For the cedar shingles weathered to driftwood silver. For the white trim that stays bright even when the siding goes grey. For the way the porches turn corners.

CAPE COD

For the steep gable, for the dormers along the roofline, and for the modest scale. This is not a Hamptons mansion — it's the cottage at the end of the road.

THE OUTER BANKS

For the way the house sits on the dune. For the unpainted pergola. For the indoor-outdoor casualness. For the Dutch doors.

THE HOUSES I KEPT OPEN IN TABS WHILE DRAWING THIS

- The Wauwinet · Nantucket, MA
- Andrew Geller's Pearlroth House · Westhampton
- The Library House · Robert A.M. Stern
- Almost every house in Sconset
- Lewis Mumford's Leedsville cottage
- The fictional Allie/Noah house from *The Notebook* (yes)
- My grandmother's house in Madison, Connecticut, which is the real reason

"Vernacular architecture is the architecture of people who have lived somewhere long enough to know what the weather wants. We don't have to invent — we have to listen."

— a professor I had once, who was right.

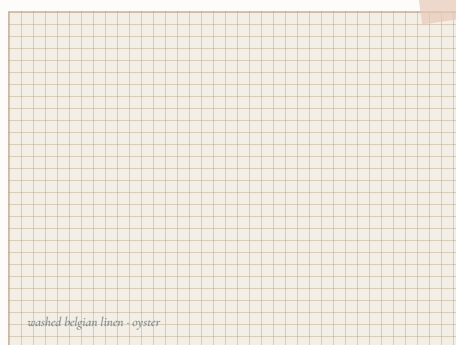
just me, ashleigh

MOOD

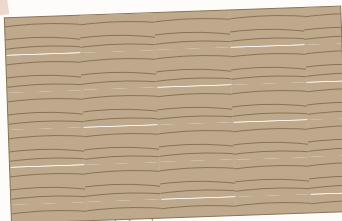
Mood board

Textures and finishes, gathered.

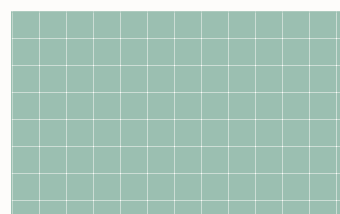
just me, ashleigh



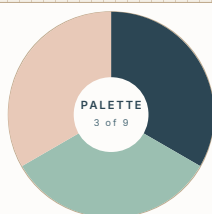
washed belgian linen - oyster



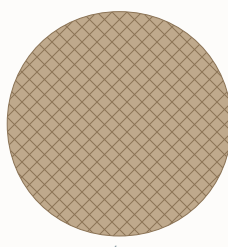
reclaimed white oak - lined



handmade zellige - sea glass



tertiary palette - deep marine, sea glass, conch



cane rattan



conch interior pink



jute & sisal - 1/2" twisted



unlacquered brass - cabinet pull



sand dollar

*quiet, sun-bleached, gently weathered.
nothing too new — every surface should look
like it's already been loved a long time.*

— ash

COLOR

The nine

Nine colors, used everywhere. Restraint is the whole point.



HOW THEY PAIR

Exterior: Foam White siding, Sea Fog shingles (over time), Deep Marine front door, Sea Glass shutters.	Great room: Foam White walls, Sea Fog ceiling, Driftwood beams, Sea Glass upholstery, Coral Bloom accents.	Bedrooms: Sand walls, Foam White trim, Deep Marine accents in the primary, Sea Glass in the bunk room.
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Paint codes are suggestions matched to common American manufacturers. For your model, any acrylic craft paint in similar tone will do beautifully — see page 38.

MATERIALS IN THE REAL COTTAGE

What she's made of

A material palette for the imaginary full-scale house — and the model proxies that stand in for them.

ELEMENT	REAL MATERIAL	MODEL PROXY	PAGE
Exterior siding	White-painted cedar clapboard, 4" reveal	¾" white foam board with scored siding lines	43, 54
Roof	Western red cedar shingles, weathered grey	Tinted craft cardstock cut into 6mm strips	45, 54
Trim	Painted cedar, ¾ stock	¼" × ⅛" balsa wood, painted Foam White	46, 53
Windows	True-divided-lite, 6-over-6 wood sash	Acetate sheet behind printed mullion overlays	46, 53
Front door	Painted Dutch door · Deep Marine	Layered balsa, painted, with brass-pin hardware	46, 53
Porch decking	Painted tongue-and-groove cedar	¼" balsa cut in 4mm strips, scored	44, 56
Foundation	Cast concrete with brick veneer skirt	Textured craft paper or thin cardstock	44, 49
Chimney	Painted-brick masonry	Foam board faced with embossed brick paper	45, 52
Pergola	Reclaimed Douglas fir, unfinished	¾" basswood, lightly stained	44, 56
Landscape grasses	Beach grass, sea oats, lavender	Static grass + dried bouquet trimmings	39, 56
Sand & path	Crushed shell & sand	Fine play sand glued to base	39, 49
Interior floors	Wide-plank limed white oak	½" balsa cut into 8mm planks, dry-brushed	44, 55

The model is meant to suggest the materials, not mimic them. A craft cardstock shingle does not have to fool the eye — it only has to read as shingle when you squint. Squinting is part of the medium.

just me, ashleigh

SETTING

The site, imagined

A 0.4-acre coastal lot with 60 feet of shoreline. The road comes in from the south; the house sits end-on so its long flank faces the ocean.

THE LOT

About 120 feet wide along the shore road, 145 feet deep down to the dune. Almost flat, with a gentle 18" rise from road to house. The lot is a peninsula of beach grass between two older cottages.

ORIENTATION

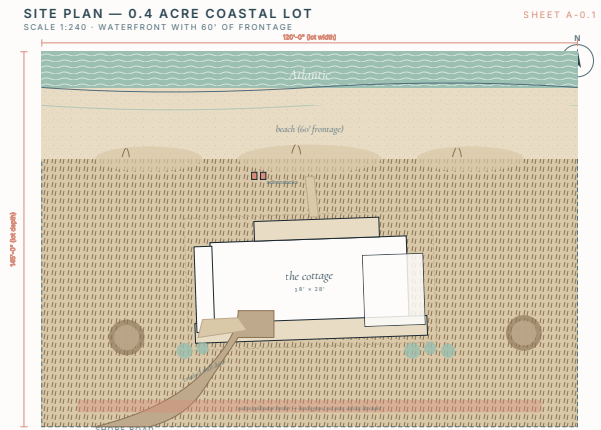
The house is oriented with its long ocean-facing wall to the north — counterintuitive for a vacation cottage, but right for this site, because that's where the view is. The wraparound porch on the south side catches the sun. The screened porch on the east catches morning light.

THE DRIVE

A curved crushed-shell drive arrives from the southeast and turns toward the cottage's east side, so guests can park out of sight from the porch and walk in.

LANDSCAPE STRATEGY

Almost no lawn. Native beach grasses, sea oats, lavender, salvia, hydrangea around the porch, and three small ornamental crab apples to give the lot scale. A path of crushed shell leads from the back deck through the dune to the beach.



The site plan in full appears on page 16 of Chapter II.

just me, ashleigh

A DAY, IMAGINED

Saturday in August

How the cottage wants to be lived in. Not a brief — a story. The architecture is in service of all of this.

6:42 a.m.

The sea fog is still on the water. You come down the stair barefoot, push the bottom half of the Dutch door open, and let coffee steam meet salt air on the wraparound porch. The dog comes too.

9:15 a.m.

The four kids have been in the bunk room since five and now they're all four on the kitchen island stools eating cereal in shifts. The pendants are on. The Dutch door is open. The screen door slams a lot. Nobody minds.

11:30 a.m.

The crushed shell path is full of bare feet going down to the beach. Sandy towels collect in the mudroom. The washer is already running.

2:00 p.m.

It rains. Hard. Three of the kids fall asleep on the screened porch daybed. The fourth reads on the great room sectional under the vaulted ceiling. You make tea.

7:30 p.m.

You eat outside on the back deck under the pergola. There are striped sailors candles and a centerpiece of hydrangeas the children cut from the porch beds. The grill is going. The ocean is silver.

10:00 p.m.

You climb the ladder to the widow's walk with a glass of wine and watch the lighthouse blink in the distance. The roof shingles are still warm from the day. The house is dark below you except for the lamp in the bunk room, where someone is reading too late again.

Every room in this plan exists to make a moment from that day possible. That's the whole brief.
just me, ashleigh

CHAPTER II

— two —

The Design

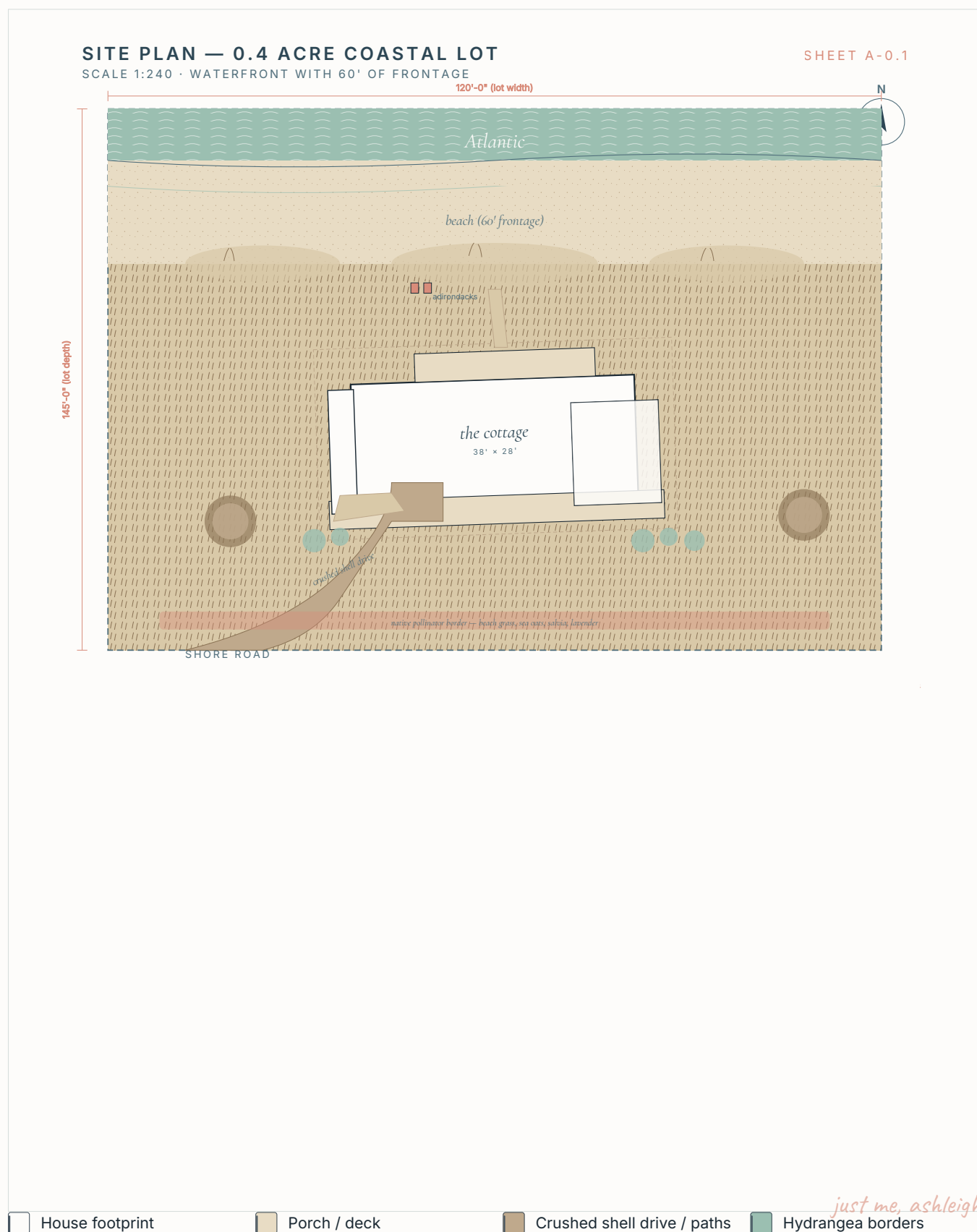
Plans, elevations, section, roof, site. Seven drawings, drawn by hand. Everything you need to understand the cottage before you start cutting it.

just me, ashleigh

DRAWING A-0.1

Site plan

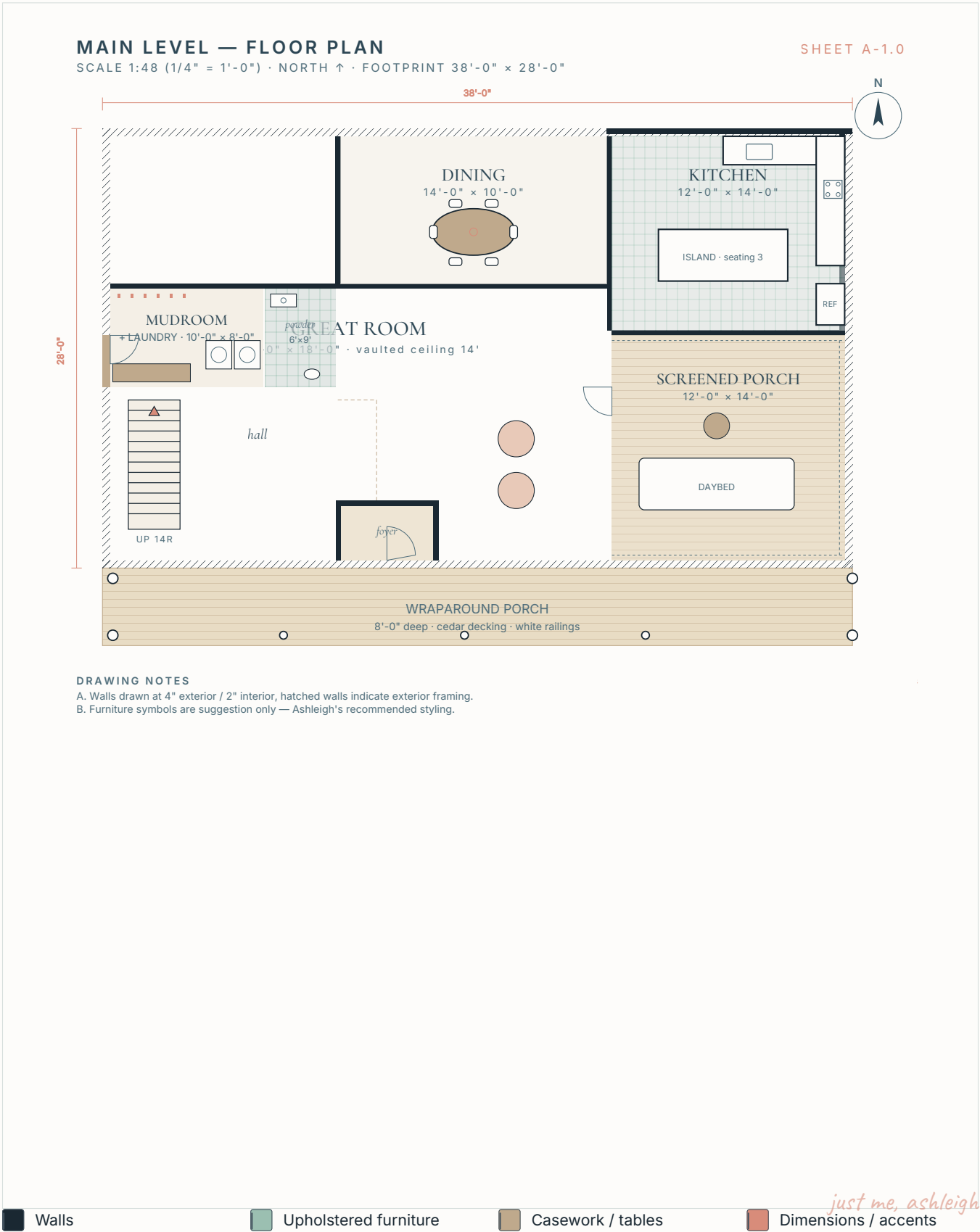
0.4-acre coastal lot, scale 1:240. Building footprint shown solid, eave overhangs dashed.



DRAWING A-1.0

Floor plan · main level

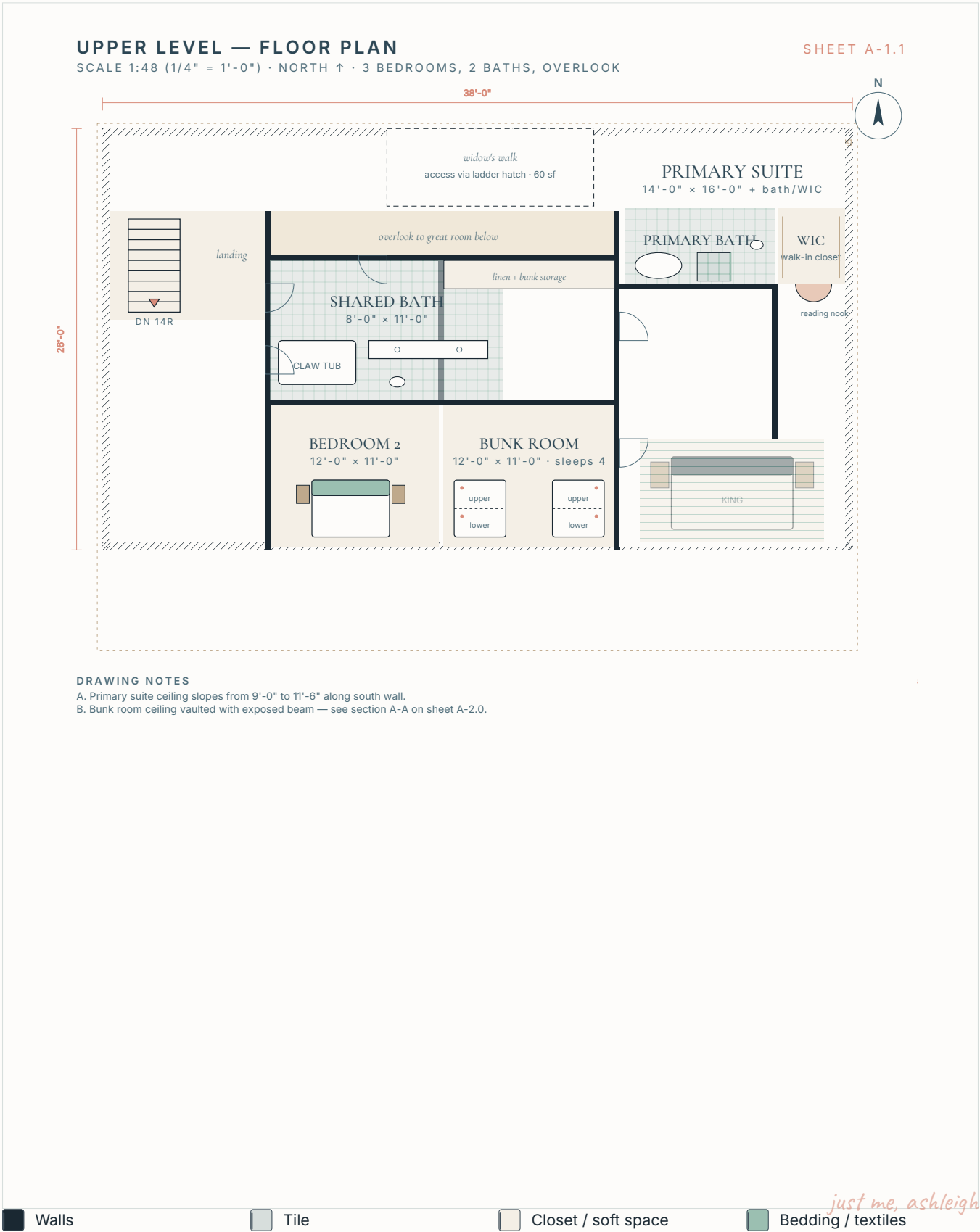
38'-0" x 28'-0" footprint. Great room vaulted to the ridge. Wraparound porch full south elevation. Screened porch on east.



DRAWING A-1.1

Floor plan · upper level

Three bedrooms, two baths, hallway overlook to the great room below. Widow's walk accessed via ladder hatch.



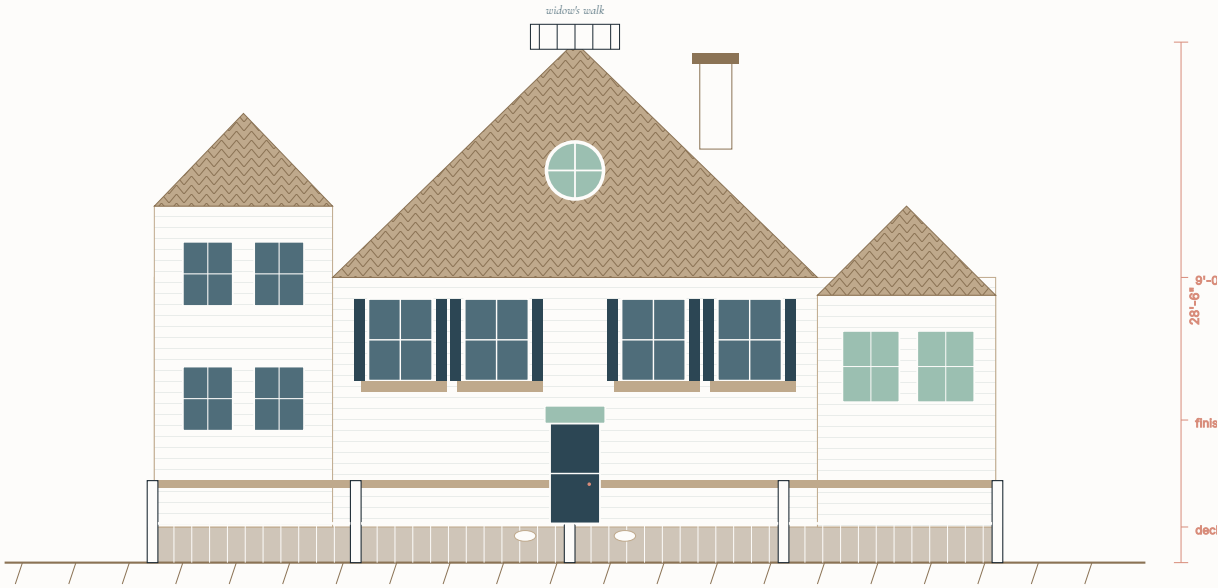
DRAWING A-2.0

Front (south) elevation

Overall height 28'-6" to ridge. Symmetry broken at left by mudroom wing and at right by screened porch wing — both intentional.

FRONT (SOUTH) ELEVATION
SCALE 1:48 · OVERALL HEIGHT 28'-6" TO RIDGE

SHEET A-2.0



MATERIAL CALLOUTS

- ① White-painted clapboard siding · 4" reveal ② Cedar shingle roof · weathered grey ③ True-divided-lite windows · 6 over 6
④ Painted shutters in 'Deep Marine' #2C4654 ⑤ Dutch door in 'Deep Marine' with sea-glass transom ⑥ White spindle railings, cedar deck

just me, ashleigh

DRAWING A-2.1

Rear (north) elevation · ocean side

Glazing concentrated here: three oversized 9-over-9 windows above, three pairs of French doors below to the back deck.



DRAWING A-2.2

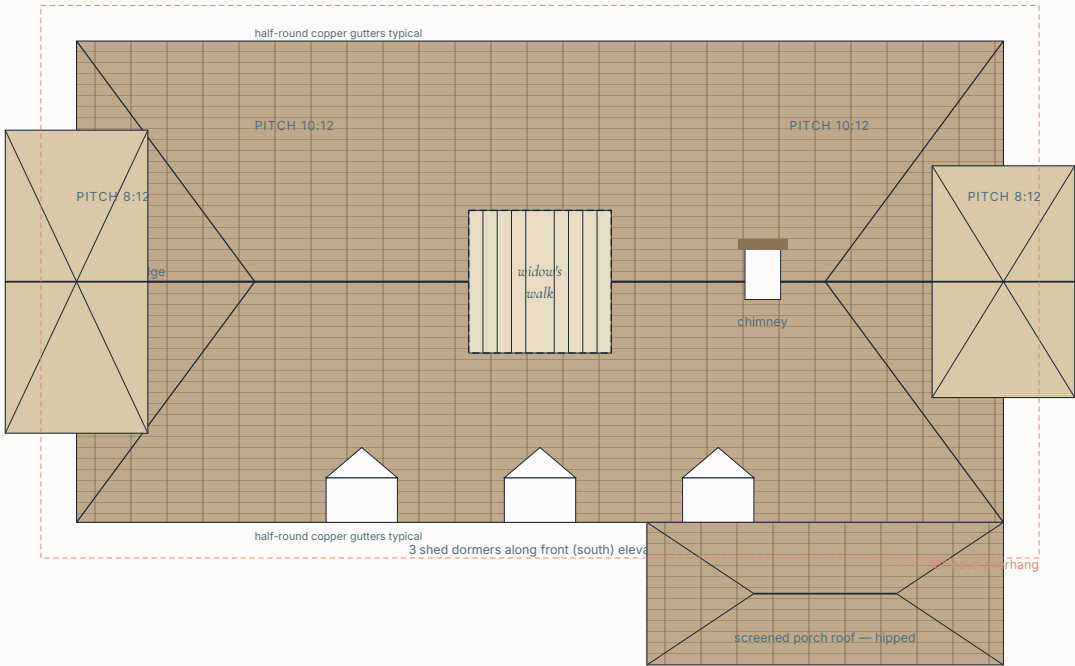
Roof plan

Main gable 10:12 pitch. Wing gables 10:12. Screened porch hipped at 8:12. Three shed dormers along the front facade.

ROOF PLAN

SCALE 1:48 · RIDGE LINES + EAVE OVERHANGS + WIDOW'S WALK

SHEET A-2.2



ROOFING NOTES

Cedar shingles applied at 5" exposure, finished naturally to weather silver. Copper flashing at all valleys, chimney, and widow's walk perimeter.

just me, ashleigh

CHAPTER III

— *three* —

The Rooms

A walk through the cottage, room by room. Each spread captures the intent: the materials, the moment of day, the lived-in feeling we're after. Style notes are recommendations — yours to obey or ignore.

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 01 · THE HEART

The great room



the great room — vaulted to the ridge, anchored by cast-stone fireplace and a sea-fog blue ceiling

THE ARCHITECTURE

Vaulted to the ridge of the main gable — 18 feet of air. Three reclaimed-oak beams cross at 4'-0", 8'-0", and 12'-0". The ceiling between is painted Sea Fog. Walls are Foam White board-and-batten to the eave line. A cast-stone fireplace anchors the east wall; ocean-facing windows fill the north wall.

THE FEELING

Big enough for everyone, soft enough to nap in. The sectional should swallow people. The rug should be old.

STYLE NOTES

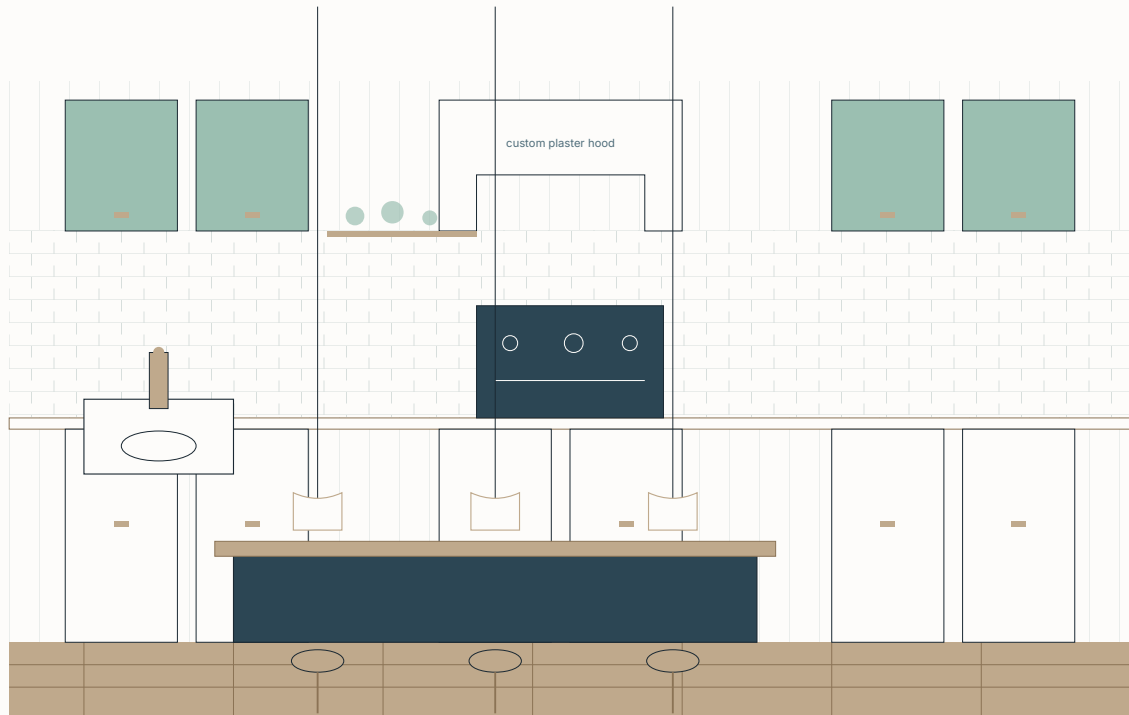
- Slipcovered sectional in washed Sea Glass linen
- Vintage Persian or jute rug, oversized
- Reclaimed-oak coffee table on iron base
- One pair of caned Conch Pink accent chairs
- Floating Driftwood shelves flanking fireplace
- Rattan paddle fan with brass arms
- Heavy linen curtains, only on the side windows

FOR THE MODEL

Vault the ceiling by leaving the upper-level floor short at the front of the model — see the cut on page 51 (Phase 3). The ceiling above the great room is one piece of Sea Fog painted cardstock glued to the underside of the roof slopes. *just me, ashleigh*

ROOM 02 · THE WORKHORSE

The kitchen



the kitchen — sea-glass uppers, soapstone counters, a custom plaster hood, and three rattan pendants over the island

THE ARCHITECTURE

12'-0" × 14'-0", open to the great room over a half-wall. Custom plaster range hood, apron-front sink under the north window, walk-in pantry tucked behind the fridge wall. A 10-foot island runs parallel to the south wall and seats three on the porch side.

THE FEELING

Working kitchen with summer-house ease. Beachgoers should be able to make a sandwich without taking off their towels.

STYLE NOTES

- Sea Glass upper cabinets with unlacquered-brass pulls
- Foam White perimeter base cabinets
- Deep Marine island base, soapstone top
- White subway tile to ceiling around hood
- Custom limewash plaster range hood
- Three caned-rattan pendants over island
- Wide-plank limed oak floor continuous from great room

FOR THE MODEL

The island, hood, and cabinets are little balsa boxes painted in the palette. Use a Sharpie-fine line to suggest cabinet doors. The brass pulls are tiny snipped headpins or wire stubs glued on. *just me, ashleigh*

ROOM 03 · THE GATHERING

The dining nook

Not a separate room — a defined moment, west of the great room, lit by a row of three windows and one big pendant. The table is round and seats six tight or eight friendly.

THE ARCHITECTURE

14'-0" × 10'-0", open to the great room with a wide cased opening. One west-facing window catches the sunset. A built-in bar cabinet on the north wall hides itself in Foam White.

THE FEELING

The first meal of the season is here. The last meal of the season is here. Most weekday meals are at the kitchen island — but Sunday lunch is here, and so is every birthday.

STYLE NOTES

- Round Driftwood pedestal table, 60"Ø
- Six unmatched cane-back side chairs
- Two cane-back armchairs at heads
- One oversized rattan pendant, low
- Built-in bar cabinet, fielded panel doors
- Slate-grey limewashed accent wall (optional)

FOR THE MODEL

Cut the round table from a dowel slice. Chairs are tiny scratch-built balsa with cardstock cane (use brown craft paper, hatch with Sharpie). The pendant is a half-sphere of cardstock painted Driftwood.

"The dining nook is a room that earns its keep three times a year and that's enough."

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 04 · THE AIRLOCK

Mudroom & laundry

First room in, last room out. The hardest-working ten-by-eight in the cottage.

THE ARCHITECTURE

10'-0" × 8'-0" west wing. Two windows look out at the hydrangea border. A 6-foot built-in bench with bins below and hooks above. Washer and dryer stacked behind a folding screen. A utility sink under the window for sandy buckets.

FLOOR & FINISHES

- Subway-pattern porcelain floor (mud-friendly)
- Sand-colored beadboard walls
- Driftwood bench with cane storage bins
- Six Coral Bloom enamel hooks at child height + six at adult height
- Single bare-bulb sconce, brass

STYLE NOTES

- Folded baskets, never plastic bins
- A row of identical buckets for shells
- A blackboard for the week's tide schedule

FOR THE MODEL

This is a small room, so detail it lightly: paint the bench, draw the bins, add hooks as snipped headpins. Don't try to model the washer/dryer — leave the screen up.

The mudroom is the only room in the cottage allowed to be messy. Plan for it.

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 05 · THE JEWEL BOX

The powder room

A 6'-0" × 9'-0" room with one job — to be the most surprising space in the cottage. Go bold here. There is no risk: it's a powder room.

THE ARCHITECTURE

Tucked under the front staircase. One small window high on the wall. Vintage console sink, brass faucet, mirrored sconces, and walls papered floor-to-ceiling in a coral-and-cream botanical print. Wainscoting in Foam White to chair height.

STYLE NOTES

- Coral botanical wallpaper above wainscot
- Carrara console sink with brass legs
- Antique mirror with painted Coral Bloom frame
- Pair of seashell sconces, brass
- Striped linen hand towel

FOR THE MODEL

Paper the walls with a scrap of pretty wrapping paper or wallpaper sample (your secret weapon — 1:48 wallpaper is just normal pattern). The sink is a wire-and-cardstock console; the mirror is a foil-tape oval framed in painted balsa.

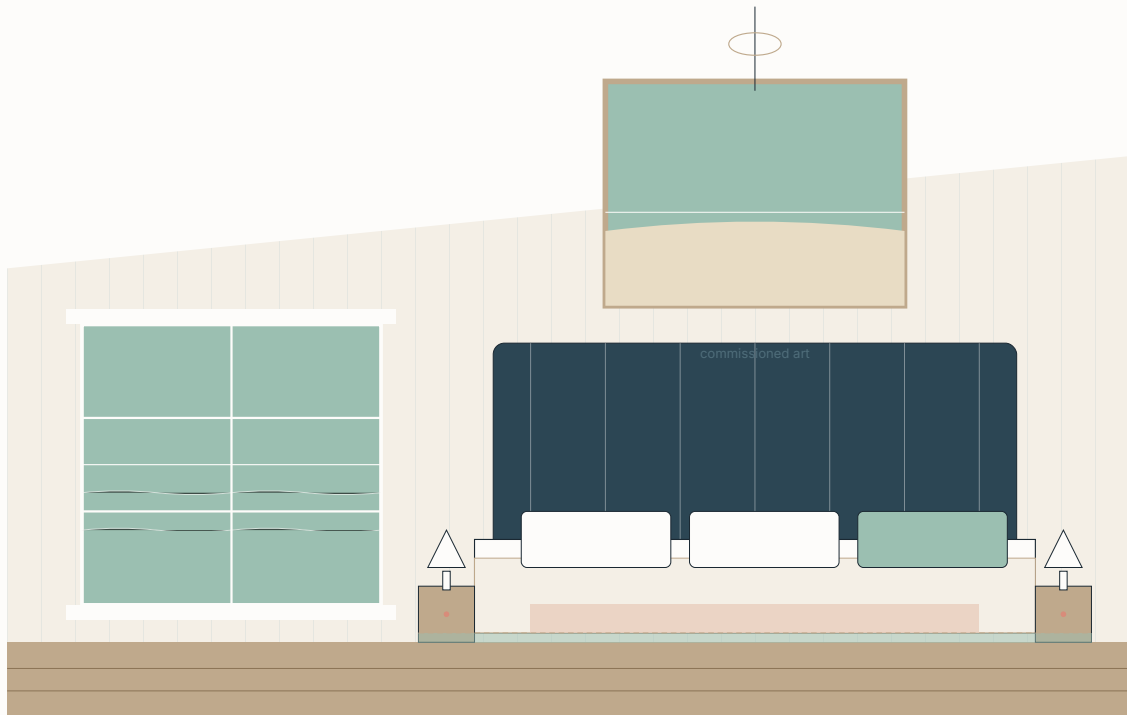
"Powder rooms are where you get to be dramatic without having to live with it."

PRO MOVE

Wallpaper the ceiling too. Trust. *just me, ashleigh*

ROOM 06 · THE RETREAT

The primary suite



the primary suite — sloped board-and-batten ceiling, deep marine upholstered headboard, ocean view to the west

THE ARCHITECTURE

14'-0" × 16'-0", east end of the upper level. Ceiling slopes from 9'-0" at the corridor to 11'-6" along the south wall. A north-facing 60"-wide picture window frames the ocean from bed. A reading nook in the southeast corner.

FOR THE MODEL

Sloped ceiling is one of the satisfying details — built from a single piece of foam scored and folded. The picture window is a single piece of acetate behind a balsa frame.

STYLE NOTES

- King upholstered headboard in Deep Marine velvet
- Board-and-batten ceiling, painted Foam White
- Driftwood nightstands, brass lamps
- Layered linen bedding: white, cream, sea-glass, conch
- One Conch Pink reading chair under window
- Persian-style runner at foot of bed
- Commissioned beach-scene oil over bed

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 07 · THE SOAK

The primary bath

A small bath with a serious soaking tub — because the primary suite is for the people who want to be in the water even when they're inside.

THE ARCHITECTURE

116-square-foot footprint with the walk-in closet borrowed alongside. A freestanding soaking tub under the north window. Curbless tile shower with a sea-glass mosaic floor. Single white-oak vanity, double brass faucets, brass-framed mirror above.

FINISHES

- Floor: 2" hex matte porcelain in Foam White
- Wainscot: 4×8 vertical handmade zellige in Sea Glass
- Shower floor: penny round in Ocean Shadow
- Tub: cast iron, Foam White exterior
- Hardware: unlacquered brass throughout
- One paper-globe pendant over tub

STYLE NOTES

- One large mounted seashell on a brass shelf
- Stacked striped linen towels, never plain
- Eucalyptus on a hook in the shower
- One small caned stool by the tub

FOR THE MODEL

The tub is the focal point — carve from a small block of basswood or scratchbuild from foam and a paint-over. The shower curb is a half-millimeter strip of balsa.

"Put the tub by a window. Always."

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 08 · THE FAVORITE

The bunk room



the bunk room — sleeps four, twin built-in bunks with rope ladders, vaulted shiplap ceiling, and a porthole between

THE ARCHITECTURE

12'-0" × 11'-0", front-east corner of upper level. Vaulted shiplap ceiling. Built-in twin bunks on opposite walls. Between them, a single round porthole window facing the porch roof — every kid's favorite window in the cottage.

FOR THE MODEL

Two simple balsa-stick frames glued to the side walls, painted Foam White. Sea Glass bands at the headboards, Conch Pink throws at the foot. Tiny rope ladders are jute twine pleated through balsa rungs. The porthole is a brass washer with acetate behind.

STYLE NOTES

- Stacked twin built-in bunks · 4 total
- Shiplap walls and vaulted ceiling, Sea Glass underside
- Rope ladders (jute, 1½" diameter)
- Individual brass reading sconce per bunk
- Curtain on each upper bunk for privacy
- One round porthole window, brass-framed
- Painted floor in Foam White with a striped runner

The bunk room is, statistically, the room everyone remembers most. Spend time on it.

just me, ashleigh

ROOMS 09 + 10

Bedroom two & the shared bath

The guest room and the bath everyone shares — designed to feel like the loveliest part of a small inn.

BEDROOM 2 · 12'-0" × 11'-0"

The grown-up guest room. Queen bed, two Driftwood nightstands, a Sand-painted writing desk under the window, a single Conch Pink reading chair. Walls in Sand, trim in Foam White. A vintage marine map of the local sound over the headboard. One striped wool rug.

- Queen iron bedstead in matte black
- White matelassé coverlet, navy ticking pillow
- Driftwood writing desk + caned chair
- Wall sconce above headboard, no overhead light
- Reproduction nautical chart, framed

SHARED BATH · 8'-0" × 11'-0"

A wide, generous bath shared by the bunk room and bedroom two. Claw-foot tub with a shower wand. Double Carrara vanity with brass faucets. Penny-round tile floor. Vintage signal pennants strung above the mirror — a small wink at the kids.

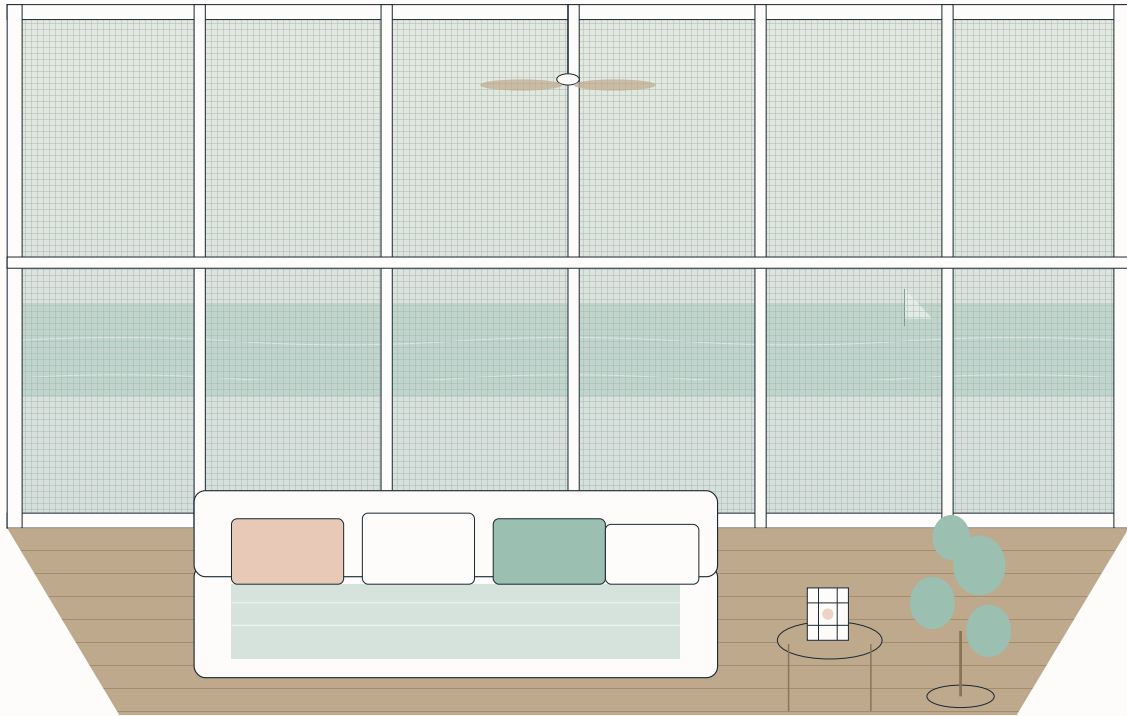
- Cast-iron claw tub, Foam White
- Single 60" double-bowl vanity
- Wide brass-framed mirror
- Pair of brass sconces, frosted globes
- Black-and-white penny-round tile floor
- Bone-colored linen shower curtain

Two small bathrooms in the same house can feel like an afterthought, or like a thoughtful little system. Use different palettes for each (Sea Glass + Brass upstairs, Coral + Brass in the powder) and the whole house will feel bigger.

just me, ashleigh

ROOM 11 · THE IN-BETWEEN

The screened porch



the screened porch — daybed, paddle fan, lantern light, and the sound of the ocean coming through the screens

THE ARCHITECTURE

12'-0" × 14'-0" east wing, hipped roof, screened on three sides. A built-in daybed along the south wall doubles as overflow sleeping. Floor is painted tongue-and-groove cedar in Foam White. Ceiling is left raw cedar planking.

FOR THE MODEL

This is the showy little room — model it openly with all four walls "screened" using fine craft tulle or vellum stretched across the openings. The daybed is balsa with a tiny linen cushion.

STYLE NOTES

- Built-in daybed with washable Sea Glass cushion
- Five mismatched throw pillows, all stripes
- Driftwood side table with brass lantern
- Single rattan paddle fan
- Outdoor area rug, layered over wood floor
- Fiddle leaf or large fern in a brass pot
- String lights along the inside top of the screens

"The best room in this house is the one you sleep on, not in."

just me, ashleigh

ROOMS 12, 13, 14 · THE OUTSIDE

Deck, pergola, widow's walk

Three outdoor rooms that work hardest of any. The house is built around them.

BACK DECK · 12 × 20

Stretches across the north of the house, accessed from the great room via three pairs of French doors. Painted cedar in Foam White. Two big planters with hydrangeas. A long teak table that seats ten.

Model: 1/16" balsa planking glued to a foam-board sub-deck. Paint white with watered-down primer for a sun-bleached look.

PERGOLA · UNFINISHED

Spans the deck with 8 × 8 cedar posts and 4 × 6 rafters. Intentionally unstained — meant to weather and to accept climbing wisteria within five years. String lights run along it.

Model: 1/8" basswood square stock, glued at right angles, lightly washed with a grey wash.

WIDOW'S WALK · 5 × 9

A small flat platform at the ridge, accessed via a ladder hatch from the upper hallway. Painted railings, four corner posts. Big enough for two chairs and a small table. Sized for sunsets.

Model: a cap of foam board glued at the ridge with a balsa railing on all four sides.

WHAT LIVES OUTSIDE

- Two oversized white planters with hydrangeas at the porch steps
- A row of three Adirondack chairs near the back path to the beach
- An outdoor shower behind the screened porch — cedar enclosure, brass fixtures
- Two strung hammocks between the pergola posts
- String lights everywhere there is a beam to staple them to
- A bell mounted by the back door, for calling people in for dinner
- One paddle-board rack on the west wall of the mudroom wing
- A long galvanized trough by the back path for hosing off sandy feet *just me, ashleigh*

CHAPTER IV

— *four* —

Materials & Tools

Everything you'll need to shop for, sourced from craft stores you already know. No specialty kits, no shipping, no waiting. Budget is roughly \$85–\$140 USD all-in.

just me, ashleigh

TOOLS

Your toolkit

Everything fits in a shoebox. If you've ever wrapped a present, you already own most of it.

TOOL	FOR	NOTES	QTY
Self-healing cutting mat (12" × 18" min.)	Cutting · scoring · measuring	Bigger is better. A2 (18" × 24") is ideal.	1
Craft knife (X-Acto or equivalent)	All cutting	Brand doesn't matter. The blade does.	1
#11 blades, fresh pack	Cutting	Change every ~30 cuts. Dull blades crush foam.	pack of 10
Metal ruler, 12"	Cutting straight lines	Cork-backed is best — won't slip.	1
Metal ruler, 18"	Cutting long walls	Optional but lovely.	1
Architect's scale	Verifying templates	Get the cheap plastic one. Adequate.	1
Pencil + soft eraser	Marking	0.5 mm mechanical, HB lead.	—
Bone folder / scoring tool	Score-and-fold walls	A butter knife works in a pinch.	1
Tweezers (fine point)	Tiny trim work	Cosmetic-grade. Lifesaver.	1
Small clamps or clothespins	Holding while glue dries	20+ wooden clothespins.	20
Sanding sponge (fine grit)	Smoothing balsa edges	Or 400 grit sandpaper.	1
Small brushes (round, sizes 0, 2, 6)	Painting	Synthetic. Cheap is fine.	3
Wide flat brush (¾")	Walls and broad surfaces	—	1
Painter's tape, ¼" + ½"	Masking	—	1 of each
Toothpicks	Glue application	Pack of 250.	—
Cup for water	Painting	Two cups, actually. Trust me.	2

"If your blade is more than a week old, change it. The most common 'I can't cut foam board' problem is a dull blade pretending to be a sharp one."

just me, ashleigh

MATERIALS · STRUCTURAL

The bones

Everything that holds the cottage up. Buy 20% extra of any sheet good — mistakes are part of it.

MATERIAL	SPEC	QUANTITY	NOTES	SKU HINT
Foam board, white, $\frac{3}{16}$ "	20" × 30" sheet	3 sheets	Walls + roof + base	ELMERS-9501
Foam board, white, $\frac{1}{8}$ "	11" × 14" sheet	2 sheets	Interior partitions, upper floor	ELMERS-9011
Chipboard or matboard	11" × 14" sheet	1 sheet	Stiffening base layer	CRESCENT-99
Balsa wood plank	$\frac{3}{32}$ " × 3" × 36"	3 sticks	Roof underlayment, deck	SIG-BHS3036
Balsa wood stick	$\frac{1}{16}$ " × $\frac{1}{8}$ " × 36"	10 sticks	Trim, mullions, railings	SIG-BWS18
Balsa wood stick	$\frac{1}{8}$ " × $\frac{1}{8}$ " × 36"	6 sticks	Porch posts, beams	SIG-BWS28
Basswood square stock	$\frac{1}{4}$ " × $\frac{1}{4}$ " × 24"	4 sticks	Pergola posts, chimney	MIDWEST-4044
Basswood plank	$\frac{1}{32}$ " × 3" × 24"	2 sticks	Floors (limed oak)	MIDWEST-4014
Dowel, hardwood	$\frac{1}{2}$ " × 12"	1	Round dining table	DOWEL-050
Wood glue, white	4 oz bottle	1	Aliphatic, fast-setting	TITEBOND-1
Tacky craft glue	4 oz bottle	1	For fabric, paper, soft assembly	ALEENES-T
Foam-safe spray adhesive	3 oz can	1	For sheet lamination	3M-77-LIGHT
Hot glue gun + glue sticks	Mini gun	1	Quick tacks, landscape	—

Estimated structural materials cost: **\$32–\$48 USD** at any large craft retailer (Michaels, Hobby Lobby, Joann, or a real model-train shop). Order ~20% extra on anything you'll cut more than five of. *just me, ashleigh*

MATERIALS · FINISHES

Surface, color, light

Paint, paper, fabric, fixtures. Where the cottage starts to look like the cottage.

MATERIAL	SPEC	QTY	FOR
Craft acrylic — Foam White	2 oz bottle (e.g. DecoArt White Wash)	2	Walls, trim, fireplace
Craft acrylic — Sand	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Sand)	1	Bedrooms, foundation skirt
Craft acrylic — Sea Fog	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Light Sage)	1	Great room ceiling
Craft acrylic — Sea Glass	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Mint Julep)	1	Kitchen uppers, shutters
Craft acrylic — Deep Marine	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Deep Midnight Blue)	1	Front door, headboard, island
Craft acrylic — Driftwood	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Mississippi Mud)	1	Beams, tables, deck
Craft acrylic — Conch Pink	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Vintage Pink)	1	Accent chairs, powder room
Craft acrylic — Coral Bloom	2 oz (e.g. DecoArt Coral Cloud)	1	Hooks, planter trim
Matte clear finish	2 oz spray, water-based	1	Sealing painted surfaces
Acetate sheet, clear	8.5" × 11", 5 mil	2	Window glazing
Brass-finish wire	22-gauge, 5 ft	1 spool	Hardware, mullions, hooks
Cardstock, white	110 lb, 8.5×11	5 sheets	Shingles, ceiling panels
Cardstock, kraft/tan	8.5×11	3 sheets	Floors, beadboard
Decorative paper / wallpaper	4×6 swatch	2 patterns	Powder room, art
Linen fabric scrap	4×4"	3 colors	Bedding, cushions, throws
Cotton ticking stripe scrap	4×4"	1	Pillows, runners
Jute twine, fine	2 mm × 10 ft	1	Rope ladders, hooks
Black fine-tip marker (Micron 005)	—	1	Cabinet lines, mullions

Estimated finishes cost: **\$38–\$60 USD**. The eight craft-paint colors are the foundation — every other paint job in the cottage is a mix of these.

MATERIALS · LANDSCAPE + DETAILS

The world the cottage sits in

A small bag of beach. A small bag of grass. A surprising amount of difference.

MATERIAL	SPEC	QTY	FOR
Play sand, fine	Pet store or craft store	1 cup	Beach, paths, mudroom dusting
Static grass, light beach (4–6mm)	Model railroad supply	1 shaker	Lawn, dune grass
Lichen / clump foliage, light green	Model railroad supply	1 bag	Hydrangeas, ornamentals
Crushed shell (or aquarium gravel)	Fine	1/2 cup	Driveway, path edges
Dried baby's breath / yarrow	Floral aisle	1 small bunch	Sea oats, dune grass
Small beads (3mm white + pink + green)	Bead aisle	1 vial each	Hydrangea blossom heads
Fine moss, dried	Floral aisle	1 small bag	Landscape detail
Brass jewelry findings (washers, headpins)	—	small pack	Hardware, sconces, porthole frames
Black headpins (1/2" length)	—	small pack	Cabinet pulls (painted brass)
Mini LED string (warm white, battery)	20 LEDs, 3 ft	1 set	Display lighting (Chapter VII)
Plastic mini Adirondack chairs (optional)	1:48 scale	2	Beach styling
Toy sailboat, 1" length	1:48 scale, optional	1	Display detail offshore

Estimated landscape + details cost: **\$18–\$30 USD**. Many of these are tiny portions of larger packs — you'll have plenty left over for future builds.

"The landscaping is half the magic. Don't skip it because you're tired at the end. Build the house, sleep, and then come back to do the planting."

just me, ashleigh

WHERE TO BUY

Sourcing guide

A short list of where to actually go, in priority order. None of this requires a specialty model-train shop, though if you have one nearby, lucky you.

1 · BIG-BOX CRAFT STORE (ONE TRIP)

Michaels, Joann Fabric, or Hobby Lobby will cover 80% of this list — foam board, balsa, all paints, brushes, glues, jute, sand, lichen, beads, fabric scraps. Bring this book; check off as you go.

Time: about 45 minutes. Coupons exist; use them.

2 · HARDWARE STORE (ONE TRIP)

For the cutting mat (if not at the craft store), a fresh #11 blade pack, a good metal ruler, and painter's tape. Also: dowels, fine wire, and any tiny finishing nails you might fancy.

3 · MODEL RAILROAD SHOP (OPTIONAL)

If there's one within driving distance, it's where to get proper static grass, fine lichen, scale figures (for scale photographs), and beautiful weathering powders. Skip if not — substitutes work.

4 · YOUR OWN HOUSE

Acetate from gift packaging. Cardstock from old greeting cards. A scrap of linen from a worn-out napkin. A jute coaster you cut up. Look around before you buy.

5 · THE BEACH

Fine sand. Three tiny shells. A piece of sea glass for the porch coffee table. Take less than you think you need.

6 · ONLINE · MY FAVORITES

If you have to order: **Sig Manufacturing** for balsa, **DecoArt** for paint, **Woodland Scenics** for landscape supplies, **Etsy** for vintage wallpaper scraps. (None of these are sponsors. They're just what I use.)

BUDGET SUMMARY

Tools (one-time)

\$22–\$40 USD

Materials & finishes

\$70–\$108 USD

All-in total

\$92–\$148 USD

just me, ashleigh

CHAPTER V

— five —

Templates

The cut sheets. Print at 100% scale, lay over your material, trace, and cut.

Calibration ruler on every page — check it with a real ruler before you begin.

just me, ashleigh

TEMPLATES

How to print & use them

Two important rules and one trick.

01 **PRINT AT 100%.**

In your print dialog, find "Actual Size" or "100%" — never "Fit to Page" or "Shrink Oversized Pages." If your printer asks about margins, accept the default. Some pages are large; they will print across two A4 sheets and need to be taped together at the crop mark.

✧ *Set printer to highest quality so the small score-lines stay visible.*

02 **VERIFY THE CALIBRATION RULER.**

Every template page has a 6" calibration ruler. After printing, lay a real ruler against it. If it measures less than 6", your printer scaled the page down — reprint with scaling corrected. A 1% scaling error is barely visible; 5% will make your roof not fit.

✧ *If the ruler is off by a known percentage, ask your printer dialog for that percentage of scale-up.*

03 **TRANSFER TO YOUR MATERIAL — DON'T CUT THE PAPER.**

The trick most people miss: don't cut your foam through the template. Instead, lay the printed template on your foam, push pin pricks through every corner and every cutout into the foam, and then connect the dots with a metal ruler on the foam itself. Cleaner cuts, reusable templates, no torn paper.

✧ *Use a fine T-pin or thumb-tack. A pencil prick works too.*

04 **LABEL EVERYTHING IMMEDIATELY.**

The moment you cut a wall, write its letter on it (A, B, C, etc.) on what will be the inside. You will not remember which wall is which once they're all sitting on your table.

just me, ashleigh

SHEET T-1

Wall templates · exterior + interior bearing

Print at 100%. Score lines dashed. Cutouts shown coral.

TEMPLATE — EXTERIOR WALLS (PRINT AT 100%)

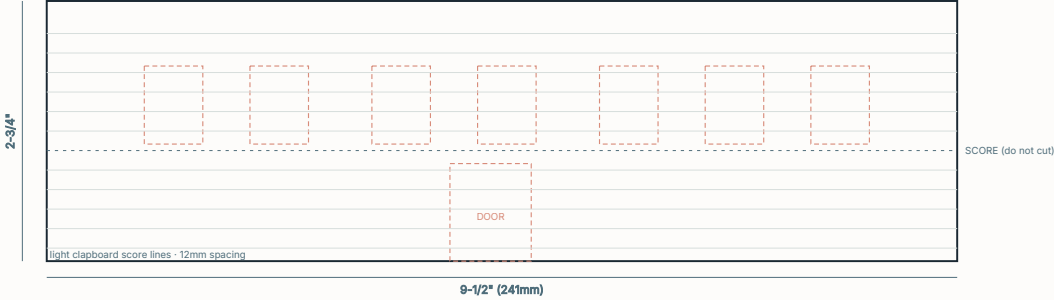
SHEET T-1.0

SHEET 1 OF 6 · PRINT ON 11×17 OR TILE A4 · CALIBRATION SCALE BELOW

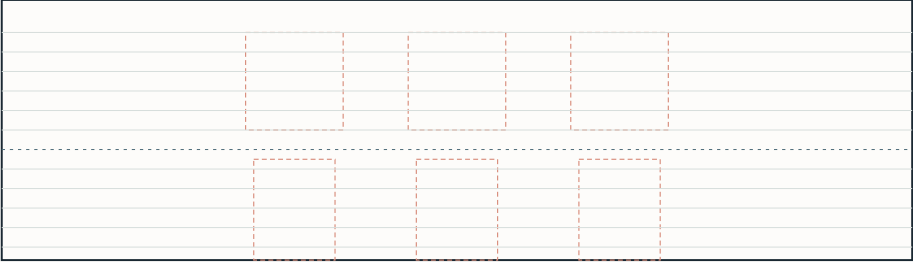


CALIBRATION: this should measure 6.0" (152mm) — adjust scale if not

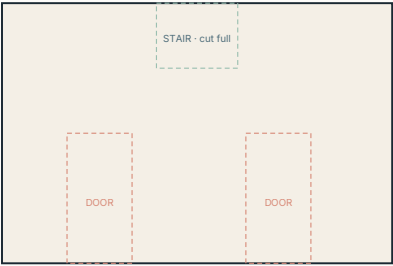
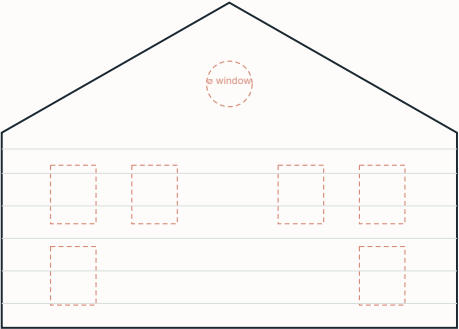
PIECE A · FRONT EXTERIOR WALL · CUT 1 · 3/16" FOAM BOARD



PIECE B · REAR EXTERIOR WALL · CUT 1 · 3/16" FOAM BOARD



PIECE C/D · SIDE WALL · CUT 2 (MIRROR) · 3/16" FOAM BOARD · PIECE E · INTERIOR BEARING WALL · CUT 1 · 1/8" FOAM



LEGEND

- cut line (use #11 blade, multiple light passes)
- - - cut opening — windows, doors, stair
- - - score line — score back of board, do not cut through
- light score for clapboard texture (very gentle pressure)

PRO TIP

Always cut on a self-healing mat with a fresh blade. Score then snap rather than cutting through in one pass — your edges stay clean and your fingers stay attached.

just me, ashleigh

SHEET T-2
Floors, base & bulkheads

Three cuts: a chipboard base, a foam main-level slab, a foam upper-level slab with overlook opening.



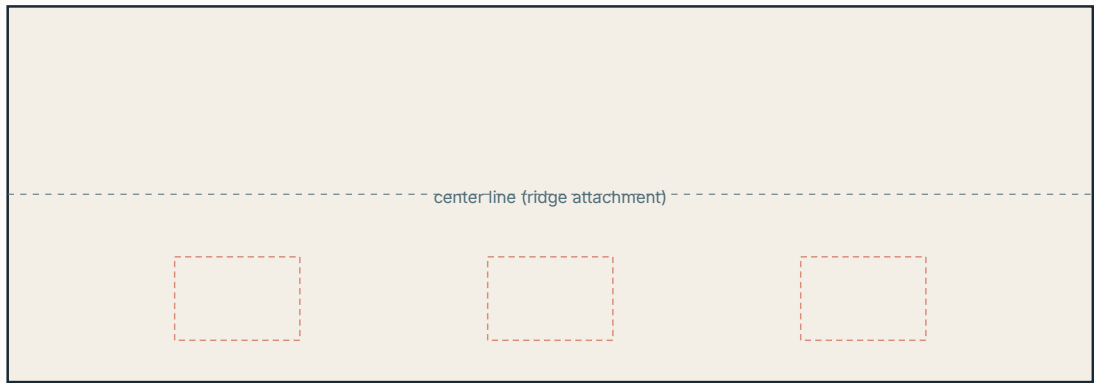
SHEET T-3

Roof panels

Four main panels, two dormer panels, three small wing panels. All cut from $\frac{3}{16}$ " foam, faced with shingled cardstock after assembly.

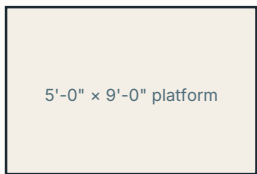
CALIBRATION 6.0" (152mm)

PIECE J · MAIN ROOF · CUT 2 (mirror) · $\frac{3}{16}$ " FOAM

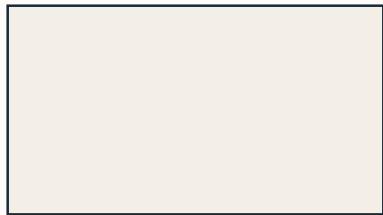


dormer cutouts (cut on south panel only)

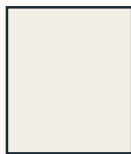
PIECE K · WIDOW'S WALK · CUT 1 · $\frac{1}{8}$ " FOAM



PIECE L · WING ROOF (LEFT) · CUT 2 (mirror) · $\frac{3}{16}$ " FOAM



PIECE M · SCREEN PORCH HIP PIECE N · DORMER CUT 6



All roof panels rest on a balsa ridge beam — see Phase 4, page 52.
Apply cardstock shingles AFTER attaching panels (Phase 6, page 54).

just me, ashleigh

SHEET T-4

Windows, doors & trim

Cut the muntin overlays from cardstock and the trim from 1/16" x 1/8" balsa.



CALIBRATION 6.0" (152mm)

MUNTIN OVERLAYS · CARDSTOCK · 6-OVER-6 OCEAN WINDOW MUNTINS · 9-OVER-9



small window · cut 14 · 6-over-6 pattern · place over acetate



ocean window · cut 3 · 9-over-9 pattern · north elevation

ROUND



cut 2 · gable + bunk porthole

FRONT DUTCH DOOR · 3 LAYERS LAMINATED BUTTERS · CUT 16 · 1/16" BALSA



- A · base balsa cut
- B · cardstock face · paint Deep Marine
- C · brass headpin door pull
- D · transom acetate behind



paint Deep Marine or Sea Glass · glue flanking each upper window

TRIM STICK CUT LIST

- Corner board (1/16 x 1/8 balsa): cut 8 @ 4.25"
- Window head trim: cut 24 @ 1.0"
- Window side trim: cut 48 @ 1.25"
- Door surround: cut 2 each @ 1.5" / 2.75"
- Porch railing top: cut 4 @ 4.0"
- Porch balusters (1/16 sq): cut 80 @ 0.75"
- Porch posts (1/8 sq): cut 12 @ 1.9"
- Pergola posts (1/4 sq basswood): cut 4 @ 2.25"
- Pergola beams: cut 6 @ 3.0"
- Ridge beam: cut 1 @ 11.5"
- Widow's walk railing: cut 4 @ 1.25" / 2.25"

just me, ashleigh

CHAPTER VI

— six —

Build

Eight phases, two to six weeks total. Each phase takes one to three good evenings. Don't rush. Don't skip the drying time. The order matters — follow it.

just me, ashleigh

PHASE 0

Set up your workspace

Spend the first evening setting up. The build goes twice as fast in a clean, well-lit space you don't have to break down between sessions.

01 FIND A PERMANENT SURFACE.

A 24" × 36" workspace minimum — a dining table is fine if you can dedicate it for a few weeks, otherwise a sheet of plywood you can slide under the couch. Cover with the cutting mat in the center and a piece of butcher paper around it for paint protection.

02 LIGHT IT WELL.

One overhead bright light + one task lamp at low angle. The low angle makes pencil lines and score marks legible — without it, you will cut the wrong line at least once.

03 PRE-SORT YOUR MATERIALS.

Lay everything out and group by phase. Shoeboxes work; cookie tins are better. One box per phase, labeled in pencil.

* Lay all the balsa flat in one place — it warps if it lives upright in a drafty cup.

04 PRINT YOUR TEMPLATES.

Print all four template pages now (43–46) and check the calibration. Don't wait until you need them — printers reliably fail at the worst moment.

05 DECIDE YOUR FINISH STRATEGY.

The cottage looks best when walls are painted **before** assembly. Paint Foam White on every interior face and Foam White on the exterior. Let dry overnight before any cutting of detail openings. Color and texture come later.

06 HAVE A WORKING PHOTOGRAPH OF THE FINISHED MODEL HANDY.

Page 4 has the axonometric. Print page 4 in color, tape it to your wall. You'll glance at it 200 times. *— Joanne Ashleigh*

PHASE 1 · ~2 HRS

Base & foundation

A flat, sturdy 12" × 9" base that everything else gets glued to. The foundation skirt is purely cosmetic but worth doing now.

01 CUT THE CHIPBOARD BASE (PIECE F).

Use template T-2 to mark and cut a 12" × 9" chipboard rectangle. This is the ground. Set aside.

02 CUT THE MAIN-LEVEL SLAB (PIECE G).

From ½" foam, cut a 9.5" × 7.0" rectangle. This is the first-floor footprint and will sit centered on the base.

03 CUT THE SCREENED PORCH SUB-DECK.

A separate 2.5" × 2.75" piece, also ½" foam, sits to the east of Piece G at the same height. Tack-glue it 1mm away from Piece G to suggest the architectural separation.

04 GLUE MAIN-LEVEL SLAB TO BASE.

Use a thin bead of wood glue around the perimeter and a few X-shaped beads in the interior. Set heavy books on top for 20 minutes.

** Center the slab so that there's about 1.25" of base showing on the front (south) and 1.0" on the north — this is your porch and deck zone.*

05 ADD THE FOUNDATION SKIRT.

Cut a ½"-tall strip of cardstock long enough to wrap the perimeter of the slab. Paint Sand color. Glue around the slab edge so the bottom sits on the base and the top sits flush with the floor.

06 PENCIL IN THE WALL FOOTPRINT.

With a sharp pencil, lightly outline where each wall will go (see floor plan, page 17). This is your roadmap for Phase 2.

just me, ashleigh

PHASE 2 · ~4 HRS OVER 2 SESSIONS

Main level walls

All four exterior walls and the interior bearing wall. Don't glue them down until everything is cut, painted, and dry-fit successfully.

01 CUT WALLS A, B, C, D (EXTERIOR) FROM $\frac{3}{16}$ " FOAM.

Use template T-1. Wall A is the front, B the rear, C and D the mirror sides. Cut window and door openings now — push the pin marks through to the foam before cutting.

✱ *For round windows: drill a small starting hole with the awl, then cut outward with a fresh blade in tiny arcs.*

02 CUT THE INTERIOR BEARING WALL (PIECE E) FROM $\frac{1}{8}$ " FOAM.

This wall separates the great room from the dining and kitchen. Cut the stair opening (full-thickness through-cut) and two door openings.

03 SAND ALL WALL EDGES LIGHTLY.

A few passes with the fine sanding sponge — the foam edges will be feathery and you want crisp lines.

04 PAINT INTERIOR FACES.

Lay each wall interior-side up. Paint with two thin coats of Foam White (great room walls), Sand (bedroom walls), or Sea Fog (kitchen accent wall). See your room palette notes. Let cure overnight.

05 SCORE CLAPBOARD LINES INTO THE EXTERIOR FACES.

Use the bone folder and metal ruler. Score horizontal lines every $\frac{1}{8}$ " up the wall. Press firmly — you want a visible indent but not a cut through.

06 DRY-FIT ALL WALLS TOGETHER USING PAINTER'S TAPE.

Stand them up, tape the corners, walk around, look at it. Adjust any tight spots. Take a photo. Sleep on it.

07 GLUE WALLS DOWN.

One wall at a time. Run a thin bead of wood glue along the bottom edge and corner where it meets the adjacent wall. Hold for 60 seconds, brace with bookends or clothespins overnight.

✱ *Glue the bearing wall second. The exterior walls help square the box.*

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PHASE 3 · ~3 HRS

Upper level & stair

The trickiest moment in the build — getting the upper-level floor cut, the great-room vault open, and the stair to land where it should.

01 CUT THE UPPER-LEVEL SLAB (PIECE H) FROM 1/8" FOAM.

Use template T-2. **Critical:** this piece is 9.5" × 6.0" (not 7.0") — the missing 1" at the south edge is what opens the great room to the vaulted ceiling above. Cut the stair opening and the overlook opening.

02 PAINT THE UPPER-LEVEL SLAB UNDERSIDE SEA FOG.

This becomes the visible great room ceiling once installed. Let dry an hour.

03 BUILD THE STAIR.

The stair is fourteen 1/16" × 1/8" balsa rises glued to two 1/16" balsa stringers. Cut each riser exactly 5/16" tall. Glue them into a step pattern. This sub-assembly is finicky; budget 45 minutes.

* *Stair tip: glue all risers onto one stringer first, then add the second stringer on top.*

04 INSTALL THE STAIR THROUGH THE UPPER-LEVEL SLAB OPENING.

The bottom step rests on the main floor; the top step is flush with the upper-level slab. Glue the stringers to the bearing wall.

05 INSTALL THE UPPER-LEVEL SLAB.

Rest it on top of the interior bearing wall and along the inside of the exterior walls. The 1" gap at the front opens the great room to the vault. Glue along all bearing edges.

06 ADD A BALSA OVERLOOK RAILING.

A 1/16" balsa cap rail with five 1/16" balusters at the front edge of the overlook opening. This is the rail the kids will lean over while you make breakfast.

07 CUT UPPER-LEVEL INTERIOR PARTITIONS AND INSTALL.

Three partition walls (primary bath, bedroom 2/bunk divider, shared bath). Each from 1/8" foam, paint first, install with thin glue lines. *just me, ashleigh*

PHASE 4 · ~5 HRS OVER 2 SESSIONS

Roof & dormers

The roof transforms the model from a box into a house. Take an extra evening here — fit before you glue.

01 CUT AND INSTALL THE RIDGE BEAM.

A single $\frac{1}{8}$ " $\times$ $\frac{1}{4}$ " balsa stick, 11.5" long. Glue it horizontally across the upper level, resting on the gable walls. This is what the roof panels lean against.

02 CUT THE GABLE END WALLS.

From $\frac{3}{16}$ " foam, cut the two triangular gable peaks (one with a round window opening). Glue to the inside of the front and rear walls, resting on the upper level slab.

03 CUT THE MAIN ROOF PANELS (PIECE J).

Two mirror panels from $\frac{3}{16}$ " foam, per template T-3. Cut the three dormer openings into the south panel only.

04 DRY-FIT ROOF PANELS.

Lean them against the ridge beam, check that they meet cleanly. Trim the bottom edge with a sanding sponge if needed for a flush eave line.

05 GLUE ROOF PANELS.

A bead along the ridge beam and along the top of each gable. Hold each panel for 90 seconds. Brace with paint cans overnight.

✱ *A small piece of folded card under each eave keeps the panel from sliding while glue sets.*

06 BUILD & INSTALL DORMERS (PIECE N $\times$ 3).

Each dormer is a small box (front, two sides, top) with a tiny gable roof. Build off-model on the cutting mat, then glue into the cutouts on the south roof.

07 BUILD THE SCREENED-PORCH HIPPED ROOF (PIECE M $\times$ 4).

Four trapezoid panels glued at their angled edges to form a low pyramid. Glue to the porch wing.

08 INSTALL THE WIDOW'S WALK PLATFORM (PIECE K) AND RAILING.

Glue the $\frac{5}{8}$ " $\times$ $\frac{1}{2}$ " foam platform straddling the ridge mid-span. Add a $\frac{1}{16}$ " balsa railing on all four sides with vertical balusters.

09 INSTALL THE CHIMNEY.

A $\frac{1}{4}$ " $\times$ $\frac{1}{4}$ " basswood square, 2" tall, with a slightly wider cap. Glue to the roof slope on the east side of the ridge. Paint Foam White. *just me, ashleigh*

PHASE 5 · ~3 HRS

Windows, doors & shutters

Where the cottage starts to look like a cottage. This phase is fiddly but extremely rewarding.

01 CUT ACETATE PANES FOR EVERY WINDOW OPENING.

Trace each opening (interior side) and cut acetate **2mm larger** all around. Glue acetate to the interior face with tiny dots of clear glue at the corners only.

02 PRINT MUNTIN OVERLAYS FROM TEMPLATE T-4.

Print on white cardstock. Cut around the outside edge of each window pattern. The muntins are the white lines printed over a dark background — when glued to the exterior face of the wall over the acetate, they will read as proper divided lights.

03 GLUE MUNTIN OVERLAYS TO EXTERIOR FACE.

Use a toothpick of tacky glue at each corner. The overlay should sit flush with the wall, framing the opening.

✱ *A second cardstock muntin overlay glued on the interior side doubles the realism. Optional but lovely.*

04 CUT WINDOW TRIM (HEAD + SIDES) FROM Balsa.

Per the cut list on page 46. Paint Foam White, then glue around each window opening so the trim hides the cut edge.

05 BUILD & INSTALL THE DUTCH DOOR.

Laminate three layers: a $\frac{1}{16}$ " balsa back, a $\frac{1}{32}$ " balsa or cardstock face, and a thin transom of acetate above. Paint Deep Marine. Score the door horizontally at mid-height to mark the Dutch split. Glue into the door opening. Add a tiny brass-headpin knob.

06 CUT AND INSTALL SHUTTERS.

Sixteen shutters, $\frac{1}{16}$ " balsa, painted Deep Marine. Glue flanking each upper window. Slight overhang above and below the window looks deliberate.

07 INSTALL FRENCH DOORS ON REAR ELEVATION.

Three pairs. Same construction as the Dutch door but full-height, painted Foam White, glazed with acetate.

just me, ashleigh

PHASE 6 · ~6 HRS OVER 3 SESSIONS

Exterior shingles & finishes

The slowest phase. Put on a movie. The shingles are about 900 individual rectangles, and they are why the model looks expensive.

01 PREPARE SHINGLE STRIPS.

Cut white cardstock into ¼" tall strips, the length of the cardstock. Lightly dry-brush the strips with a wash of 70% Foam White, 25% Sea Fog, 5% Driftwood — the weathered-silver look. Let dry.

02 SCORE INDIVIDUAL SHINGLES.

With the back of the craft knife, score vertical lines every ¼" along each strip. This gives you visible shingle joints without separating each one.

03 APPLY SHINGLE STRIPS TO THE ROOF.

Starting at the bottom (eave), glue one strip across, then a second strip overlapping the first by ⅛". Offset the score lines by ⅛" between rows for a brick-bond pattern. Work upward.

✱ *A small clip clamp on each just-laid strip while glue sets prevents lifting.*

04 CAP THE RIDGE.

A folded strip of cardstock, painted, glued over the apex where the two roof slopes meet.

05 PAINT EXTERIOR SIDING.

Two coats of Foam White on every clapboard wall. Two coats. Three on any spots that look thin.

06 ADD CORNER BOARDS AND FRIEZE TRIM.

⅛" × ⅛" balsa, painted Foam White, glued vertically at every exterior corner and horizontally just under the eaves.

07 INSTALL THE WRAPAROUND PORCH DECK.

Cut ⅜" balsa into 4mm strips, score them with the bone folder, paint Foam White slightly washed, glue to the front base in horizontal courses.

08 ADD PORCH POSTS & RAILINGS.

Twelve ⅛" basswood posts, 1.9" tall. Top each with a thin balsa cap. Glue eighty balusters between posts in ⅛" stock. Paint everything Foam White.

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PHASE 7 · ~5 HRS OVER 2 SESSIONS

Interior finishes

Almost done. Floors, fireplace, kitchen island, fixtures. The cottage gets warm.

01 INSTALL INTERIOR FLOORS.

Cut ½" basswood into 8mm-wide strips. Cut to length, glue down on the upper- and lower-level floors in a running bond. Dry-brush with a Foam White wash to suggest "limed" oak.

02 BUILD THE FIREPLACE.

A small 1.5" × 1" × 0.5" foam block, faced in cardstock, painted Foam White with a Driftwood mantel and a Deep Marine firebox inset. Glue to the east great room wall.

03 BUILD KITCHEN CASEWORK.

The lower cabinets are a 1.5"-tall × 0.5"-deep balsa box running along the kitchen wall, painted Foam White. The island is a 2" × 0.75" balsa box painted Deep Marine with a Driftwood top. The hood is a folded cardstock trapezoid painted Foam White.

04 BUILD UPPER BATH FIXTURES.

The freestanding tub is a small balsa carving (rough block, sand into oval). The toilet and sink are tiny scratch-built foam shapes. Don't overdetail — these will be seen from above.

05 BUILD BUNK BEDS.

Two simple twin-bunk frames in ¼" balsa, painted Foam White, with Sea Glass cardstock headboards. Add tiny linen scraps for bedding.

06 BUILD THE PRIMARY SUITE HEADBOARD.

Cut a 2" × 1" cardstock rectangle, wrap in Deep Marine fabric scrap, glue to the suite wall. The bed itself is a balsa frame in front, dressed with linen scraps.

07 HANG ART AND ADD FINISHING DETAILS.

Tiny rectangles of pretty paper for art. Brass-wire sconces flanking the primary bed. A scrap of striped fabric on the daybed. A little bell over the back door.

* *Less is more inside. Suggest a sofa, don't sculpt a sofa.*

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PHASE 8 · ~3 HRS

Landscape & final styling

The cottage lands on its lot. Don't skip — this is where she becomes her.

01 PAINT THE BASE.

Paint the visible chipboard base in tan and pale green washes for ground. Don't be precious — most of this will get covered.

02 LAY THE CRUSHED-SHELL DRIVEWAY.

Brush a thin layer of tacky glue from the south edge of the base curving up to the east side of the cottage. Sprinkle crushed shell or aquarium gravel. Press down. Brush away excess.

03 LAY THE BEACH.

The north 1.5" of the base is beach. Brush tacky glue, sprinkle fine sand. Tap, tilt, brush. Sand the front of the dunes higher than the back.

04 PLANT THE STATIC GRASS.

Brush tacky glue in the front yard, dune line, and side beds. Shake static grass over generously. Let dry 30 minutes, then tip the model upside-down over the trash to remove the loose grass.

05 ADD HYDRANGEAS AT THE PORCH STEPS.

Cluster 3mm beads (mix white, pink, pale blue) on small tufts of lichen glued at the front porch corners. Each hydrangea is about ¼" wide.

06 PLANT THE DUNE GRASS.

Snip baby's breath or yarrow into ¼"–½" lengths. Insert into pinpricks along the dune line. They lean naturally.

07 ADD PATH OF CRUSHED SHELL FROM BACK DECK TO BEACH.

Same technique as the driveway, but ¼" wide.

08 STYLE THE PORCH.

Two tiny clay-pot planters at the front door, one twig hammock between pergola posts, one small Adirondack chair pair at the dune line. Stop styling before you think you should.

09 SIGN THE UNDERSIDE OF THE BASE.

Your initials, the date, "built from a Just Me Ashleigh plan." This is your house.

just me, ashleigh

DISPLAY

Display & lighting

A small house deserves a small stage. A few thoughts on where to put her, and how to light her.

WHERE SHE BELONGS

On a bookshelf at eye level, or on a low console where you can see her from a couch. Avoid direct sunlight — UV will fade the cardstock shingles. A glass cloche is overkill but extremely cute.

BACKGROUND MATTERS

A neutral wall behind her (Foam White or Sand) lets the colors of the cottage do their work. A bookshelf full of books behind her competes; consider clearing the row immediately behind.

ADD A TINY OFFSHORE DETAIL

A 1" toy sailboat or buoy sitting on the base just north of the beach implies the ocean continues — a small narrative trick that triples the apparent scale of the scene.

LIGHTING · THE MAGIC MOVE

Run a battery-powered warm-white LED string (the kind for fairy-light wedding centerpieces) up through a small hole in the base under the great room. Snake the cord through the bunk room and primary suite. With three or four LEDs lit, the cottage glows from within at dusk like a real house.

✧ Use a USB-powered fairy light set if you display on a powered surface — no battery changes.

PHOTOGRAPH HER

Shoot in late-afternoon natural light, low angle, with a child or small object in the foreground for scale. Tag @justmeashleigh — Ashleigh saves every one.

*"Build it to live with, not to keep on a shelf
you never look at."*

just me, ashleigh

CARE

Care & longevity

A well-built model from this plan will last decades. A few small habits will help.

DUST MONTHLY

A soft makeup brush or a clean dry watercolor brush is the right tool. Compressed air is too much — it can rip shingles off and rearrange landscaping. Brush gently from roof down.

KEEP HER DRY

Foam board and cardstock both warp with humidity. Avoid bathrooms, kitchens, basements with damp air, and rooms with radiators that get steamy in winter.

SUN IS THE ENEMY

UV will yellow the white paint and fade the colors over years. A north-facing room is ideal; otherwise a sheer curtain helps. If you must put her in a sunny window, plan to retire her there only for the summer.

WHEN SOMETHING BREAKS

It will. A balsa railing piece will pop off; a shingle will lift. Keep a small repair kit in a labeled envelope: spare cardstock shingles, a tiny tube of tacky glue, a #11 blade, a toothpick. Most repairs take three minutes.

MOVE WITH CARE

If you need to move the cottage, lift from the base only — never from the roof or walls. Carry with two hands. Box her in a slightly oversized box stuffed loosely with paper if traveling.

WHAT SHE'LL DO OVER TIME

The cardstock shingles will deepen in color. The balsa trim will warm. The paint will mellow. If she's well-cared-for, she'll look better in five years than she did the day you finished.

*"An object made by hand carries the maker.
Decades from now, someone will pick this
cottage up off a shelf and know that you cared.
That is the whole point."*

AND IF YOU WANT TO MAKE HER AGAIN

You absolutely can — this plan is licensed for unlimited personal builds. Many builders make the second one as a gift. The second build takes half as long and looks twice as good. *just me, ashleigh*

MAKE IT YOURS

Customizations

A starter list of small adjustments that change the whole feeling. None of them break the plan — pick one, pick three.

DIFFERENT CLIMATE

Lake house — swap shingles for white-painted board-and-batten siding, add a stone foundation. **Mountain** — add a metal roof, stain the siding cedar dark, replace pergola with covered porch.

DIFFERENT PALETTE

Pink cottage — Foam White siding, Conch Pink front door + shutters, Coral Bloom inside the porch ceiling. **Storm Grey** — Sea Fog siding from day one (no weathering), Deep Marine door, brass everything.

DIFFERENT FAMILY

Empty-nesters — combine the bunk room and bedroom 2 into one large guest suite. **Big family** — add a second set of bunks where the shared bath linen closet is. **Solo retreat** — wall off the upper level for a single primary, turn bunk room into a studio.

DIFFERENT ROOF

Gambrel — Dutch-colonial vibes; the upper level gets more headroom. **Hipped** — softer, more Hamptons. **Standing-seam metal** — modern coastal; use thin painted aluminum tape.

DIFFERENT SCALE

1:24 (½" = 1'-0") — print templates at 200%, double the materials. Plays beautifully with miniature furniture. **1:64 (Hot Wheels scale)** — print at 75%, simplify trim. Fits in a shoebox.

DIFFERENT SEASON

Christmas cottage — wreaths at every window (snipped lichen), candles in the panes, snow on the roof (baking soda on tacky glue). **Autumn** — orange and red leaf litter, pumpkins at the door.

"Customization is the most architectural thing you can do. The plan is the start of the conversation, not the end."

just me, ashleigh

THANK YOU

Send me a photo.

If you got this far — if you cut every shingle and glued every baluster and signed your name to the underside of the base — please, please send me a photo.

There is nothing in the world like seeing one of these little houses sitting on someone else's shelf, lit from the inside, the work of someone else's hands. Every cottage from this plan will look a little different and every one will be right. The plan is a frame; you are the painting.

Tag **@justmeashleigh** on any platform and I'll see it. Or write to **hello@justmeashleigh.com** with a picture — I read every one.

If you'd like the next plan when it comes out (a tiny mountain A-frame, a city brownstone, a French cottage with a tower) you can subscribe at **justmeashleigh.com**. New plans are released seasonally.

Thank you for spending your weeks with this little house.

Thank you for trusting my drawings.

Thank you for caring about a small thing.

— Ash

ashleigh · the dream house atelier · this spring



Concept Plan No. 001
The Saltwater Cottage
First Edition · 60 pages
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